In the first phase, it grouped in FATA, where its old connections established during Afghan jihad sheltered its leaders. However, very soon the Pakistan security forces started an operation against them and the Taliban. Resultantly, the leaders started leaving FATA and moved towards the bigger cities of Pakistan, especially Punjab, where they operated clandestinely, far away from the area under scrutiny.

In the second phase, Al Qaeda leaders found safe houses, logistic support and transport in these cities with the help of the activists of religious parties and jihadi organisations (Fair, 2009). Hamza Rabia, the operational chief of Al Qaeda, and his family lived in Lahore for 6 months in 2003–4.[14] A number of Al Qaeda commanders were arrested in the cities from 2002 to 2005, including Abu Zubaydah (Faisalabad), Khalid Sheikh Mohammed (Rawalpindi), Naeem Noor Khan, alias Abu Talha (Lahore), Ahmed Khalfan Ghailani (Gujrat), Amjad Farooqi (killed in Nawabshah) and Abu Faraj al-Libbi (Mardan near Peshawar).

After the arrests of Al Qaeda's key leaders in Punjab, it returned to its original safe haven, for instance, FATA and started regrouping there (Musharraf, 2006). It was the beginning of the third phase. However, they were again under intense pressure from the Pakistani military operation and the US drone attacks. More than 50 Al Qaeda commanders had been killed by drone attacks in FATA until 2016.

The documents recovered from the hideout of Hamza Rabia, the operational chief of Al Qaeda, and Ahmed Khalfan Ghailani, in Gujrat (2004), revealed that the Al Qaeda leaders hiding in the Pak-Afghan border did not want to fight with the Pakistani army, but rather wanted to focus their attention on the US. Most of the army encounters therefore took place with the Uzbek desperadoes. The origin of the TTP could be explained by this logic and the policy of Al Qaeda to avoid direct skirmishes with the Pakistan Army and let the locals perform this job (Musharraf, 2006).

Al Qaeda was thought to have 5,000–12,000 members (Abuza, 2003). Different intelligence agencies had provided different data about the strength of Al Qaeda at various times. Abuza (2003) admitted that the number of people trained at the camps Bin Laden established in Afghanistan is unknown; German police estimated it to be approximately 70,000. The US Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) estimation was between 15,000 and 20,000. Most became foot soldiers in an international brigade, also called the Arab brigade that